



The Selectboard
TOWN OF WESTHAMPTON
TOWN HALL
1 SOUTH ROAD
WESTHAMPTON, MASSACHUSETTS 01027

Minutes of the Meeting

Wednesday, April 15, 2026, 7:00 PM
at the Town Hall, 1 South Road

CALL TO ORDER - Selectboard

The Selectboard meeting was called to order at 7:03 PM

PRESENT: Johndrow, Milikowsky, Bronstein (Chair).

Ms. Bronstein offered introductory comments, noting that public comment would be held until the end of the meeting.

CALL TO ORDER– Finance Committee

The Finance Committee was called to order at 7:04 PM

PRESENT: Albitz, Dempsey, Durrin, Holt, Milikowsky, Stanton, Weiss (Chair)

Review of Finance Committee Minutes of April 9, 2026

After review, it was MOVED by Albitz, SECONDED by Stanton

To approve the draft minutes of April 9, 2026.

VOTED: 7, 0, 0. (7:05 PM)

DISCUSSION – Proposition 2-1/2 override ballot, FY2027 Budget

Selectboard and Finance Committee will discuss the results of the Proposition 2-1/2 ballot, review and consider the FY2027 budget. May make changes to the FY2027 budget, give direction to staff, and may take votes.

Mr. Weiss noted the recent vote, and the failure of the override. (314 for – 373 against)

Ms. Bronstein noted that the turnout was high, and the information sessions likely made a difference in the turnout. The absence of any contests at the caucus was also noted.

Mr. Weiss noted that, to prepare a balanced budget, three potential actions could be taken –

- Use of reserves / free cash
- Reduction in budgets
- A second Prop 2-1/2 override

Mr. Weiss noted the urgency in the committee's work ahead, and that Town Meeting would have an opportunity to debate the various options. However, he hoped that the Selectboard and Finance Committee could find consensus on how to proceed.

Mr. Albitz: Do we wait until Town Meeting to get to a balanced budget? Mr. Weiss: To do so would result in a very long town meeting that could likely last multiple sessions. My goal is to make decisions in advance of Town Meeting and prepare a balanced budget that uses an

override, cuts, or use of free cash for Town Meeting to consider.

Ms. Milikowsky expressed concern with suggesting use of free cash, making cuts, or proposing another override without looking at the budget on a closer scale.

Ms. Dempsey and Ms. Bronstein agreed.

Mr. Weiss suggested that review of the budget would proceed.

Review of budget changes that lowered the deficit from \$500k over the past six weeks (“down” means lowering of deficit, “up” means increasing deficit)

- Changes to vocational education down \$35k
- Changes to vocational transportation up \$10k. It was noted that we pay roughly twice what local towns pay. We need to negotiate a better contract – as noted by Milikowsky. Further, it was noted that LPVEC transportation has gone from a few hundred dollars to \$12k in a short couple years.
- Changes to elementary school (REAP Grant attained) down \$27k
- Changes to regional school request up \$20k
- Reduction in snow removal budget line down \$40k (will be voted on at TM instead)
- Restoration of PILOT revenue down \$64k (solar)
- Additional Health Care Insurance costs up \$30k
- Misc down \$4k

The current deficit with the above noted changes was estimated at \$389,893.

The board and committee heard a proposal for a revolving fund that would capture revenue from renewable energy projects, and to apply those funds for repairs and upgrades to public buildings in Westhampton.

Mr. Weiss suggested that the committee and board could consider potential changes to the budget:

- Eliminating or restoring stipends for elected and appointed officials
- Eliminating or restoring the COLA for employees
- Reducing highway crew from 4 to 3

Deliberation

Mr. Weiss noted that he would not personally support exclusive use of savings to close the budget gap. Broad concurrence.

There was some deliberation about how to proceed, with some conversation about details of specific budgets.

Mr. Weiss conducted a straw poll of FinCom to determine how members would close the budget gap, through some combination of Free Cash, Cuts and an override.

The results of the poll were reviewed and considered. Of those participating on FinCom, the results were roughly 1/3, 1/3, 1/3 for the three options to close the deficit. There were variations in the polling suggesting some would choose a lower override number and/or higher use of free cash. Furthermore, it was noted that a \$130k override would result in an increase in taxes of about \$49 per \$100,000 of assessed property value.

Mr. Bill Tracy suggested the use of \$190,000 of stabilization, \$100,000 from free cash, and request another override of \$100,000.

Chief David Antosz advised the boards to be aware of the ripple effect of reduction of staffing, and how it may cost the town in the long run. Chief Antosz also noted the significant role that emergency services play in town and advised against any reductions.

Mr. Brad Morse suggested that an override for \$500,000 poisoned the well, and that it would be a hard sell to win a second override vote.

Expense Report

The most recent Expense Report was reviewed. No votes taken.

Next Steps

Mr. Weiss asked if there was consensus relative to how the deficit would be addressed.

Discussion on that point. No votes were taken but it was generally agreed upon that the straw poll suggested a 1/3-1/3-1/3 approach was close to the average opinion of FinCom.

Mr. Weiss suggested that the Finance Committee would need to identify \$130,000 in cuts across town and elementary school budgets. Discussion on that point. No votes taken.

General consensus: The Finance Committee needed to conduct a review of all budget lines in order to determine where savings could be found to close the budget deficit.

Calendar

Mr. Weiss suggested two meetings on Wednesday the 22nd and Wednesday the 29th of April, with school admin and school committee reps expected to attend on the 29th. Mr. Weiss expressed concern that the final budget must be approved and complete by May 6th.

ADJOURN (Selectboard)

It was MOVED by Milikowsky, SECONDED by Johndrow
To adjourn.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0. (9:12 PM)

ADJOURN (Finance Committee)

It was MOVED by Durrin, SECONDED by Milikowsky
To adjourn.

VOTED: 7, 0, 0. (9:12 PM)